

BAIS: International Relations

Non-Western IR Theory

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In-Class Survey

Scan the QR code or follow the link below.



https://leidenuniv.eu.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_3DeqB8XCr2l9vDw

Your Questions, Our Toolkit

You Had Questions

From the Week 3 survey

After last week's lecture, several of you shared things you would like us to address. A few themes stood out:

- What is driving the “new world order” – why are leaders like Trump and Putin acting the way they are?
- What role does North Korea play in rising global tensions – and could it spark a wider conflict?
- Could major powers fight a conventional war without it going nuclear?
- How does the arms industry shape international politics?
- Can we go deeper on Cold War dynamics and U.S.-Russia rivalry?

Good questions. Let's talk about how to approach them.

Theory as a Compass

Contemporary events matter – they affect our lives and shape the world we inhabit. But reacting to the news is not the same as understanding it. **What theory gives us:**

- A way to **organize** complexity – not just “what happened” but *why*
- Tools to **compare** across cases and time periods
- A framework for **evaluating** competing explanations
- The ability to step back and identify **patterns** rather than merely react to events

What We've Built So Far

Week 1 – Old Debates in a New World

- Three competing visions of the post-Cold War order: liberal triumphalism and “the end of history,” civilizational conflict, and the return of great-power competition

Week 2 – Traditional IR Theories

- Realism (power, anarchy, self-help), liberalism (institutions, interdependence, cooperation), and constructivism (norms, identity, social construction)

Week 3 – Security Dilemmas and Nuclear Proliferation

- The security dilemma, three models of why states build the bomb, the optimist-pessimist debate

The “New World Order”

Why are leaders like Trump and Putin acting the way they are?

Week 1 – Which post-Cold War vision holds up?

- “The end of history” predicted liberal triumph – yet authoritarian resurgence suggests otherwise
- “The clash of civilizations” anticipated cultural fault lines – but today’s rivalries cut across civilizational blocs
- “The return of history” argued great-power competition never disappeared – the liberal order rested on American power, not inevitable progress

Week 2 – Three lenses on the same events:

- **Realism:** Balance-of-power logic and security competition (NATO expansion, spheres of influence)
- **Liberalism:** Erosion of institutions and treaties that constrained great powers (INF, New START, alliances)
- **Constructivism:** Identity projects – Russian nationalism, “America First” – redefine what states see as their interests

Week 3 reinforces this: the collapse of U.S.-Russia arms control is a concrete manifestation of great power competition.

North Korea's Nuclear Program

What role does North Korea play – and could it spark a wider conflict?

Week 3 – Sagan's three models applied:

- **Security:** Existential threats (U.S. forces in South Korea, no peace treaty) – nuclear weapons as a survival guarantee
- **Domestic politics:** The regime uses the program to consolidate power, justify military-first policy, and maintain elite loyalty
- **Norms:** “Nuclear state” status is central to regime identity and claims to international prestige

Week 3 – The proliferation debate:

- **Optimists:** Deterrence may be working – no major conflict on the Peninsula since 1953
- **Pessimists:** Risks of miscalculation, opaque command-and-control, and the stability-instability paradox

The limits of our toolkit

These frameworks were built to explain Western states and Cold War dynamics. How well do they capture a state outside the liberal order, with a distinct political culture? This is where non-Western IR theory comes in.

But Whose Theories Are These?

Every framework we have used so far – realism, liberalism, constructivism – emerged from a Euro-American intellectual tradition.

- When we ask “why is the world order changing?” – whose concept of *order* are we using?
- When we analyze North Korea or China – are we applying frameworks designed to explain *their* behavior, or frameworks built by and for Western states?
- What do thinkers outside this tradition see that we might be missing?

Today's lecture

Non-Western IR Theory – how scholars from beyond the Euro-American tradition understand power, order, and conflict. This is essential for making sense of the very questions you raised.

IR as a Western Project

“An American Social Science”

IR theory's foundational concepts reflect European and American historical experience.

- **Sovereignty, balance of power, nation-state** – all derived from the Westphalian system
- The discipline took shape in the U.S. and U.K. after two world wars and the Cold War
- Key debates (realism vs. liberalism, the “great debates”) were internal Western conversations

The consequence

Theories we treat as *universal* were built to explain one region's history. Applying them globally risks mistaking the particular for the general.

What Gets Left Out

Western IR theory assumes the Westphalian state system as the default. But Asia had its own international systems – and they looked very different.

Alternative systems

- The Chinese *tributary system* – hierarchy, not anarchy
- The Southeast Asian *Mandala* system – overlapping authority, not fixed borders
- Multiple coexisting “international orders” across Asia

What this means for theory

- Non-Western actors are reduced to “data points” for testing Western theories
- Their agency, ideas, and historical experiences are overlooked
- Alternative forms of order are treated as deviations from the norm

Why Does This Matter?

Why has non-Western IR theory been slow to develop? **Structural barriers:**

- **Institutional:** Major journals, publishers, and conferences are Western-based
- **Policy pull:** Non-Western scholars often focus on policy rather than theory-building
- **Language:** English dominance marginalizes other scholarship
- **Area studies vs. IR:** Non-Western regions are siloed as “area studies,” not IR theory
- **Hegemonic acceptance:** Non-Western scholars internalize the assumption that Western theory is “better”

NWIRT: A Different Starting Point

Dimension	Traditional IRTs	NWIRT Approach
Structure	Westphalian anarchy as the universal condition	Multiple historical international systems (tributary, Mandala, etc.)
Agency	Great powers drive the system; non-Western states respond	Non-Western actors as norm-makers, not just norm-takers
Historiography	European history as the baseline for generalization	Multiple regional histories as sources of theory
Epistemology	Primarily positivist; universal claims	Pluralist; local knowledge and experience as valid foundations
Sources	Western political philosophy (Thucydides, Hobbes, Kant)	Non-Western thought (Kautilya, Ibn Khaldun, Confucian traditions)

Adapted from Acharya (2014), Table 7.1.

Asia and the Limits of Western Theory

Asia and the Limits of Western Theory

How do Western theories explain Asia –
and where do they fall short?

The debate

Asia's post-Cold War security order has been remarkably stable – but Western IR theories disagree about why, and whether it will last.

“Ripe for Rivalry” vs. “Asia’s Past”

Friedberg’s pessimism

- Asia lacks Europe’s stabilizing mechanisms (NATO, EU, deep integration)
- Rising powers, unresolved disputes, historical enmities
- Asia is “ripe for rivalry” – great-power conflict is likely
- Framework: *neorealism applied to Asia*

Kang’s alternative

- Asia has a tradition of *hierarchical order* with China at the center
- Historically, Asian states bandwagoned rather than balanced
- A rising China may restore stability, not threaten it
- Framework: *culturalist realism*

Note

Both approaches apply Western theoretical frameworks to Asia. Neither starts from Asian historical experience on its own terms.

Acharya's Critique

Neither pessimism nor nostalgia gets it right.

- The **balancing vs. bandwagoning dichotomy** is too narrow
- **Engagement and “double-binding”**: Asian states enmesh *both* China and the U.S. in regional institutions
- **Regional norms**: nonintervention, consensus, multilateralism actively shape behavior
- **Institutions**: ASEAN, ARF, ASEAN+3 are genuine mechanisms of order – different from NATO or the EU, but real

Key insight

Asian states are not passive recipients of great-power dynamics. They actively construct their own regional order.

Perspectives on Asian Regional Order

Perspective	Structure	Agency	Prognosis	Theoretical basis
Realism	Multipolar, anarchic	Great powers	Conflict likely	Balance of power
Neorealism	U.S. hegemony or bipolarity	Great powers	Stability via deterrence	Structural constraints
Liberalism	Interdependence	States + institutions	Cooperation possible	Institutional design
Constructivism	Norms-based	States + norms	Depends on identity	Social construction
NWIRT	Multiple, historically grounded	Regional actors	Engagement and localization	Deprovincialization

Adapted from Acharya (2014), Table 7.2.

What Are the Takeaways?

Each main theory captures something real about Asian security – but none captures enough.

- **Realism** highlights power competition but cannot explain why Asia has been more stable than predicted
- **Liberalism** recognizes institutions but assumes they must look like Western ones to work
- **Constructivism** takes norms seriously but often treats non-Western norms as local curiosities rather than theoretical contributions

This is not just an academic problem

If our theories misread Asia, our policy prescriptions will too. Getting the theory wrong has real-world consequences.

Break

We will resume in 10 minutes.

Let's discuss what the survey revealed.

Three things to discuss:

1. Knowledge check: How well did you engage with the readings?
2. Key findings: What patterns emerged?
3. Connecting to today's lecture: How do the results relate to what we have discussed so far?

Toward a Global IR

Three Pathways for Non-Western IR

1. **Extend and adapt Western IRT**

- Add non-Western cases to existing theories
- Risk: non-Western experience remains supplementary

2. **Build on Asian exceptionalism**

- Develop theories from uniquely Asian concepts (*Tianxia*, “Asian values”)
- Risk: replaces one particularism with another

3. **Global IR** (Acharya’s preferred path)

- Draw on multiple traditions without privileging any single one
- *Expand* the scope of IR theory, not replace it

The Dangers of Exceptionalism

- **“Asian values”** – used to justify authoritarian governance (Singapore, Malaysia in the 1990s)
- ***Tianxia* and tributary nostalgia** – essentializes Chinese civilization, romanticizes hierarchy
- **Mirrors Western universalism in reverse** – replaces one provincialism with another
- **Homogenizes “Asia”** – treats a vast, diverse continent as a single intellectual tradition

The problem

Replacing Western parochialism with Asian parochialism does not produce better theory.

What Is Global IR?

The goal is not to discard Western theory – it is to *expand* the discipline's foundations.

- Recognize Westphalian concepts as *one* historical tradition, not the universal default
- Avoid purely indigenous or culturalist alternatives – the goal is dialogue, not isolation
- **Constitutive localization:** foreign ideas *blended* into local normative settings
- **Subsidiarity:** local norms diffused outward into global governance

“Global IR is not about rejecting the Western IR tradition, but *broadening* the scope and sources of IR to make it more inclusive and universal” (Acharya, 2014).

Global IR in Practice

Non-Western contributions to global norms already exist.

- **Nonintervention and nonalignment:** championed by Asian and African states, now foundational norms
- **ASEAN regionalism:** consensus-based, sovereignty-respecting alternative to the EU model
- **Human security:** conceptualized by Mahbub ul Haq (Pakistan), adopted globally via UNDP
- **ZOPFAN:** Southeast Asian initiative to keep the region free from great-power competition

The point

Asian ideas have already traveled globally. Global IR recognizes this – it does not start from scratch.

A Case Study: IR in Postcolonial South Korea

Korea's "Twisted Postcoloniality"

How a non-Western country builds its IR discipline

- **Colonized by Japan (1910–1945)** – a non-Western colonizer, same regional sphere
- After liberation: Korea rejected *both* Japanese and traditional Korean knowledge systems
- The Korean War and U.S. alliance created deep dependence on American intellectual frameworks

Result

Korean IR scholars embraced American IR wholesale – not out of ignorance, but as a survival strategy for a weak, war-torn state.

Building Korean IR Under Western Hegemony

Two strategies – both face the same structural trap.

Universality-focused

- Positivist, American-compatible
- Publish in SSCI journals
- Risk: *mimics* American IR

Particularity-focused

- Korean historical experience
- Primarily domestic audiences
- Risk: remains *marginal*

The paradox

Both reinforce Western hegemony – universalists mimic American IR, particularists remain isolated.

What Does the Korean Case Tell Us?

South Korea is wealthy, democratic, and has strong universities. If *any* non-Western country could build an independent IR tradition, it should be able to. And yet:

- **Institutional barriers** – promotion tied to Western journal publication
- **Intellectual barriers** – decades of American training constrain alternatives
- **Political barriers** – security dependence on the U.S. reinforces intellectual dependence

Connecting back to Acharya

Structural forces – not a lack of ideas or talent – constrain the development of non-Western IR. This is why Global IR must be a collective project, not a demand that non-Western scholars “catch up.”

Wrapping Up

Key Takeaways

1. **IR theory has Western origins** – its core concepts reflect one region's history, not universal truths
2. **Western theories fall short in Asia** – the balancing/bandwagoning dichotomy misses engagement, norms, and institutions
3. **Exceptionalism is not the answer** – replacing one parochialism with another solves nothing
4. **Global IR expands the discipline** – not replacing Western theory, but broadening IR's scope and sources
5. **Structural barriers are real** – institutions, incentives, and power dynamics constrain who gets to theorize

Questions to Consider

Think about these before next week:

1. If IR theory is shaped by the historical experience of the societies that produce it, can any theory truly be “universal”?
2. How might constitutive localization and subsidiarity apply beyond Asia – to African or Latin American contributions to global governance?
3. What is the relationship between Global IR and the critical and decentring perspectives we will encounter next week?

Next Week: Critical and Decentring Perspectives

Week 5 (Prof. Wolff):

- Heywood & Whitham, *Global Politics*, Ch. 4
- Additional readings on Brightspace

Next week builds directly on today's material – from questioning Western IR's dominance to exploring critical alternatives.

Thank you!

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